

Organizational Ambidexterity Assessment: A study conducted within the context of Cuenca, Ecuador

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Abstract

Organizational Ambidexterity (OA) requires balancing operational efficiency (exploitation) with innovation (exploration). This study analyzes the manufacturing sector in Cuenca, assessing whether the industry adapts proactively or if its priority on stability limits its future competitiveness.

Objectives

General Objective

Evaluate ambidexterity in study organizations in Cuenca, based on criteria established in the literature.

Specific Objective 1

Identify organizational ambidexterity measurement methods through a systematic literature review.

Define the sectors in which organizational ambidexterity may be reflected.

Specific Objective 2

Identify the risks and opportunities to which an ambidextrous organization is exposed through a critical literature review and a Delphi study

Specific Objective 3

Calculate the level of organizational ambidexterity in the case study companies.

Specific Objective 4

Metodology

1

The PRISMA protocol was applied to provide a theoretical foundation for the study. This analysis enabled the identification of the key dimensions of Organizational Ambidexterity (OA) and the structuring of the proposed evaluation model.

To ensure the reliability of the instrument, a Delphi method was conducted with experts in the field, focusing on risks and opportunities.

2

3

The level of Ambidexterity was evaluated using a method validated in the literature, analyzing sectors, risks, and opportunities within the proposed model.

Curricular Integration

- Quality Management
- Operations Research
- Analytical Statistics
- Inferential Statistics

Applied Engineering

- ISO 9001
- CIU Classification
- PRISMA Protocol
- Delphi Method

Constraints: limited access to information and data.
Social: managerial conceptual gaps;
Technological: contextual methodological misalignment.

This was used in order to define, validate, and develop the analytical model.

Keywords

Ambidexterity

Exploration

Exploitation

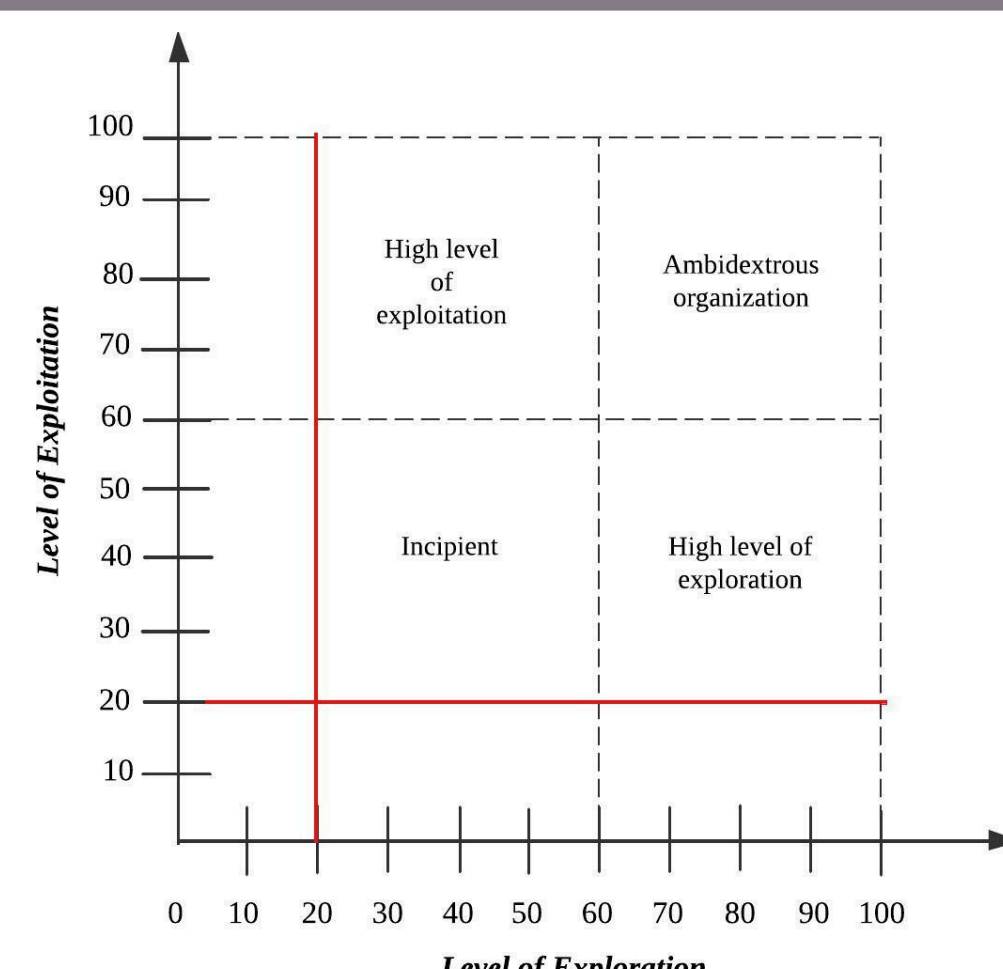
Evaluation

Innovation

Cuenca

Results

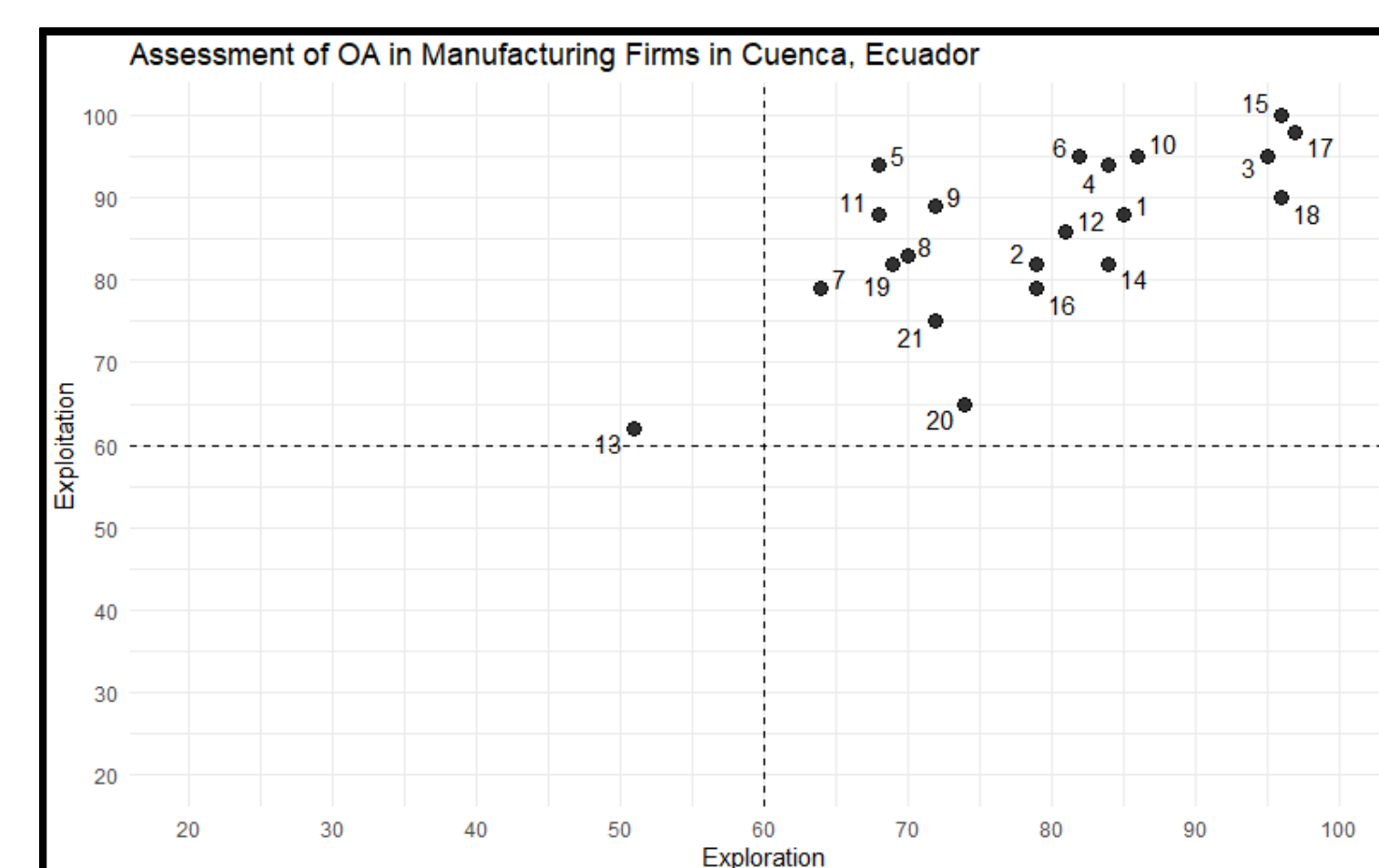
It was found that the most commonly used methods to evaluate OA are structural equation models (SEM), followed by regression models and qualitative approaches. These studies predominantly focus on developed economies and with high sample size requirements.



Identified sectors: manufacturing; information and communication; accommodation and food services; commerce; and education. The manufacturing industry was selected due to its predominance in the literature and its national economic impact, representing 12.8% of Ecuador's GDP (2024), in addition to its high simultaneous demand for operational efficiency and innovation.

It was determined that the environment acts as a key moderating factor, where economic uncertainty and technology drive defensive ambidextrous strategies, prioritizing operational efficiency over disruptive innovation.

The empirical evaluation showed that most manufacturing firms in Cuenca are located in the high-performance quadrant, evidencing the coexistence of exploration and exploitation, although with a clear orientation toward efficiency and reactive innovation.



Conclusions

Conclusion 1

The business environment in Cuenca has developed a high-performing ambidextrous organization (AO), operating under a hybrid logic as a mechanism for survival and competitiveness. However, this capability is not static; it is a constant dynamism conditioned by the pressure to maintain daily operations in a volatile environment.

Conclusion 2

A specific evaluation instrument was developed for emerging economies, integrating ISO 9001 standards with AO theory for the local context. This tool surpasses generic scales by enabling diagnostics based on tangible process indicators, facilitating the identification of biases toward over-exploitation or lack of innovative discipline.

Conclusion 3

Although exploration and exploitation coexist, there is a marked bias toward operational efficiency. Innovation does not follow proactive planning but rather a defensive response to political and economic instability, prioritizing immediate liquidity over the risk of diversifying into new markets.

Conclusion 4

Despite the observed maturity, financial constraints and cultural resistance to change limit ambidextrous potential. It is concluded that current success risks becoming future obsolescence if innovation is not formalized, transforming present efficiency into a mechanism for more systematic exploration.

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